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DIVIDED SANCTUARY

Claiming the Hagia Sophia, Turkey's religious battleground

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Watching the Watchdog

Journalism and partisanship in the Trump Era

BY **MAAYAN SCHOEN**

WILLIAM SHERMAN REMEMBERS THE DAYS when writing a breaking story was a race against the printing press schedule and carried the potential for jail time. In the Nixon era, he stood before a judge's bench for refusing to reveal the sources behind his exposé of Vice President Spiro Agnew's now-notorious corruption. In 25 minutes, Agnew pleaded "no contest" in exchange for his resignation, and Sherman avoided prison. Sherman left his court appearance victorious and immediately wrote to the world that Agnew was resigning.

In another era, Sara Carter recalls a regular day covering troops in Afghanistan and enjoying a helicopter ride when her team heard an explosion—and had to bring dead bodies onboard. Looking at a lifeless young man by her side, she thought of his mother back home who had no idea that this story—so different from the ones being told in Washington—was about to hit newsstands.

Investigative journalists have been reporting since America's earliest days, printing often inconvenient truths to keep power in check. From John Peter Zenger's *New York Weekly Journal*, to radio broadcasting in World War II, to Twitter in 2016, the platforms for reporting have evolved while the exploits of the elite have not.

When hyper-polarization characterizes national affairs, journalists are often called on to account for their biases in their reporting. The pendulum of partisanship and the media's entrenchment therein swings back and forth, mused Carter in an interview with *The Politic*, but print news today is still not as partisan as it was at America's inception, when political parties printed their own newspapers. Many publications today at least try to be objective in their news reporting, even if they more openly lean "left" or "right" in their opinion sections.

The implications of Donald Trump's presidential tenure on the production and consumption of news media are ripe for retrospection. The media played an especially prominent role in Trump's presidency, and asking "why" and "how" this was so generates important considerations. Is it because of the demands that Trump's rise to power imposed on investigative journalists? Or perhaps the media acted according to a nefarious agenda. Did Trump frustrate news outlets by often breaking his own news on Twitter and staging unbelievable antics in the pressroom? Or perhaps the antagonism between Trump and the media was mutual from the beginning.

When distrust of the media dominates, as it does now, it is necessary to consider whether the media is at fault or being used as a scapegoat.

Veteran writers at the forefront of investigative journalism during the Trump era largely agree about the ideal role of journalism today, despite working for publications perceived as ideologically at odds. Trump's presidency called for agents of America's free press to mobilize, and they answered the call. Sherman, a decorated retired journalist, and Ellen Shearer, professor of political journalism, offered both praise and criticism for today's publications—with a hopeful eye toward the future. They also lamented the economic challenges shuttering local newspapers, which are key to building back public trust in the media.

Journalism is in transition, they contend, and refining best journalistic practices will enable journalists to continue working for democracy.

THE TRUMP ERA was defined by a non-stop stream of media accusations against the president and the president's charges against his news adversaries, revealing what happens to journalism in an age of huge information flow and extreme polarization. At many times throughout Trump's administration, the state of American affairs resembled an open investigation—and while reporters were the main whistleblowers, some regarded them as suspicious sources. But despite fumbling accusations of "fake news" across the partisan aisle and occasionally being singled out for criticism by the president, journalists from across the political spectrum agree that they continue to do what they have always done: Inform the people, give voice to the voiceless, and demand transparency.

"The whole thing was really kind of an entirely new phenomenon," reflected *The New York Times* investigative reporter Mike McIntire in an interview with *The Politic*. Trump's rise to power "really demanded investigative reporting at a level that hadn't been done before."

McIntire, a professor of journalism at New York University and a two-time Pulitzer prize-winner, got his journalistic start reporting for several local Connecticut newspapers, where he covered the corruption of former Governor John Rowland and the 1998 mass shooting at Connecticut Lottery Corp headquarters. He also broke some of the most major stories about former President Trump, including the *Times* investigation into Trump's recent tax returns.

Journalists watching a toxic political culture ascend with Trump could not turn away.

"You had a wink and a nod to white nationalists, and racists, and conspiracy theorists, and anti-immigrant groups," McIntire described, "and so all of these things came together to demand increased media attention, because they were worth it."

Speculation concerning America's geopolitical adversary Russia also imposed demands on journalism from the time of Trump's candidacy. McIntire noted that this context precipitated "all these investigations and clouds of suspicion surrounding his entry into the White House." McIntire won a Pulitzer in 2017 for covering Russian election interference.

He denied that the media's extensive focus on Trump and the Republican party over the past five years represented a flaw in modern journalism. "This is not a partisan political thing," he said. "We're guided by First Amendment principles of freedom of the press, and with that comes a rather solemn responsibility to serve as a check on power."

Although Trump's presidency dominated over four years of media coverage, "it was important for the country and for democracy itself, as we painfully learned on January 6, to cover this stuff and investigate how it is that these forces were unleashed on American society," McIntire stated.

Carter's perspective on the media during Trump's presidency, however, is quite different. While she also responded to political circumstances through her reporting, Carter felt compelled to cover aspects of the Trump administration that she felt the media neglected or distorted.

"There was this vile hatred for Trump" among journalists and politicians, she said. "It's such a deep-seated hatred, that for some people, it was almost blinding."

The problem for the public is that "you can't legitimately understand what's going on if the press as a whole has it out for a candidate," explained Carter, recounting Washington Christmas parties at which journalists spoke openly of the need to convince the ignorant American public of Trump's unfitness. "They wanted to remove this man from office."

Carter considers herself socially liberal and says that the best journalists "are service-oriented." In Carter's view, partisanship in journalistic coverage is also about what is omitted or ignored.

Conservative Fox News host Sean Hannity, she said, was one of the few willing to promote her work covering misconduct in the Mueller investigation and FBI misconduct—spying on citizens—based on unreliable information from Christopher Steele's dossier. It was unpopular to criticize Trump's adversaries, Carter explained, at a time when Washington reporters believed their job was to "[save] people from Trump."

To Carter's surprise, mainstream print publications never took her investigations any further. Carter believed that "with all of the resources and all of the great journalists" at publications such as the *Washington Post* and *The New York Times*, the stories she brought to light would explode in the media.

"And then there were 'crickets.'"

Carter made the decision to transition from investigative journalism to being an investigative columnist, a switch she feels allows her to react transparently and responsibly to media bias.

"I talk more about my politics now, and I want the audience to be aware of that," Carter explained. Carter's personal distinction between commentary and news is one that many believe is missing from the media at large.

"It wasn't that I was supporting Trump," she said. "If I had found out that President Trump was having secret meetings with Vladimir Putin, guess what? I would be the first reporter, and I would say it on Sean Hannity's

show, without hesitation."

PROFESSOR SHEARER OF NORTHWESTERN UNIVERSITY has made a career out of teaching best practices for American political reporting. Her expertise includes being co-Director of Northwestern University's Medill National Security Journalism Initiative, a professor of political journalism, Washington bureau chief at Medill News Service, and the former president of the Washington Press Club.

"I think what you're seeing more on either ends of the political spectrum is really a throwback to a much earlier time in journalism," she said, "when the press was more partisan in the early days of the Republic."

"It doesn't mean their articles aren't accurate," Shearer clarified, "but they have a point of view." She offered great praise for the many journalists who have endured Trump's personal attacks and still continued doing good reporting.

Sherman believed letting Trump's words speak for themselves was often most powerful. These past four years were "a Trump daily reality show," said Sherman. "So all you had to do was…let him talk."

One example of where the media may have gone wrong, despite good intentions, Shearer suggested, is in their increasing utilization of anonymous sources close to the government. She also echoed concern for reporters' tendency to offer commentary as news. Most dangerous, however, were journalists who offered factually inaccurate information as either

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commentary *or* news. "Op-ed writers have a point of view, but they usually use facts to support them," she reasoned.

Despite difficult circumstances and instances of bias, "I think you've seen some of the best journalism being practiced," Shearer maintained. She noted that the media had to familiarize itself with many fields of knowledge in order to inform the struggling public, including politics, public health, climate change, and race.

For Sherman, higher powers antagonizing the press is nothing new. On his way to collecting Pulitzers, an Emmy, and a Peabody, Sherman posed as a poor New Yorker to uncover Medicaid abuses, met with Cambodian Dictator Pol Pot, and was jailed in Iran.

But "all through the '60s, and then the '70s of Watergate hearings, all the different events, reporters did not opine," he said. "They just reported."

Sherman believes papers should strive for the kind of separation between opinion and news he saw in his experience at *The New York Daily News*.

"The same day I would have a news story about Agnew taking bribes for sewer contracts, the editorial page would have this long editorial about Agnew: What a great guy he was, 'unfounded allegations,' et cetera," he recalled.

Technological developments have brought readers closer to stories. Sherman explained that journalists began to take advantage of multimedia technology in the Vietnam War, galvanizing anti-war movements just by allowing people to see what was happening.

"[Reporters] would film battles, soldiers walking through the jungle, and guys getting shot and dying. You can hear the gunfire and the warplanes, the horror of this war," Sherman recalled.

Journalists who literally immerse in the story bring personal accounts to readers. Sherman gave *The New York Times* reporter Bill Laurence as the example.

"They let him fly on the plane to drop the atomic bomb. And he wrote a first person account of that," said Sherman.

From fighter planes to Twitter feeds, journalists have a responsibility to separate news reporting from opinion. This is possible if their goal is seeking the truth.

PROFESSOR SHEARER HOPES journalists will reflect on bad practices cultivated during the Trump era and implores them to limit their skepticism and editorializing. "I think we have to be very careful…that we draw a line and make sure we're sticking to the facts and not taking the difficulties we had in covering President Trump and overlaying them on to other other areas," warned Shearer.

A central challenge for the media during the past four years was the public's distrust, prompted by the normalization of the term "fake news" by Trump and his administration. The term became "a way to dismiss and criticize any particular story that was inconvenient for them, or that they just didn't like," said McIntire.

While "that's not a new phenomenon," McIntire admitted, Trump was "especially adept" at it.

"The whole problem of people… deciding which facts they will accept… is something that's going to take a long time to get past," added Shearer, and is "a really unfortunate result of some of President Trump's rhetoric."

"I think certainly one of the things we've seen is that there's a big market out there amongst people to want to hear what they already believe.... And that's a problem," said McIntire, because "all you get there are self-reinforcing biases, that may not reflect reality."

Genuine belief in election fraud, McIntire noted, resulted in the January 6 insurrection and highlighted a challenge journalists had "in terms of just making sure that by covering [Trump], you're not merely parroting false things that he said."

At the same time, McIntire and Shearer agree that some organizations distort news through media personalities who push profitable agendas.

"I think commentary is important. But I think it's got to be labeled and should be separate," said Sherman.

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He considers CBS to be the classic example of a broadcasting organization that distinguished commentary from news reporting on the viewer's behalf.

To Carter, the real issue is with publications that purport to be objective and trustworthy while harboring a hidden agenda.

"I, for the most part, believe that humans are smart and can make their own decisions," said Carter. To her, that would mean realizing that television pundits such as Sean Hannity of Fox news and Rachel Maddow of MSNBC are giving their opinions, and not just news—which she says that they make quite apparent.

Though CBS anchorman Walter Cronkite was once considered "the most trusted man in America," Sherman said that "it's swung back the other way now," and print media has become more trustworthy than radio or television, though they retain trusting audiences. Unfortunately, "CBS television is a more powerful medium than newspapers," he said.

Trump's accusations against reporters went further than 'fake news.' He alleged that journalists were un-

There's usually more than two sides to anything."

patriotic. Shearer quoted Washington Post reporter Marty Baron's response: "We're not at war with the administration; we're at work."

"The news media did not create partisanship," said Shearer. Violence against journalists because of such accusations pressured reporters "to keep their heads down and get the story, while worrying about their safety."

While Americans typically associate violence against journalists with foreign regimes, escalating hostility toward the media has brought those risks closer to home. In the outrage that followed the 2018 shooting at the *Capital Gazette*'s newsroom in Maryland, which killed five employees, many journalists reckoned with safety they had taken for granted.

Carter also reflected on the flow of partisanship between the people, the government, and the media at the national level.

"I think [partisanship] is exacerbated by the media, and it's frightening," said Carter, "because the media is a tool, and information is, to me, the greatest weapon of all."

It is not that people are not allowed to have agendas. "Everybody has an agenda," said Carter. "That's why when you have a newspaper, you're supposed to have people with varying viewpoints, keeping a checklist, kind of like our government. But the only way for people to understand right and wrong is if you tell them everything."

BEFORE 2016, VETERAN journalists said that the field was dying. For many reasons, Trump at America's helm revived it.

"One of the big legacies of the Trump era is the importance of investigative journalism," said McIntire.

However, Sherman thinks that ratings will drop under the Biden administration.

News consumers "salivating for the next story that might reveal something negative about [Trump]... are now having to contend with the fact that in a Democratic presidency, the news media is going to do its job there as well, and do critical stories when necessary about the Biden administration," said McIntire.

This is not a bad thing for journalists.

"I think the pace will be less intense now that former President Trump is not on Twitter," Shearer evaluated.

In truth, [she said], "it's a service job."

"And I think for the better, just because that was an unsustainable model for thoughtful discussion."

Social media platforms such as Twitter have been huge elements of the news experience under the "Tweeter-in-Chief." Carter worries that "we moved faster than we can think about the results," though she recognizes the potential of social media as a platform for discourse.

Social media is at once a hub of useful information for reporters, a center for disinformation, a platform for sharing stories instantaneously, and a mistake for journalists who use the platforms to share personal opinions.

Journalism may look different than the days when these journalists yelled "hold the presses!" to break a story, as Carter fondly reminisced, but there are plenty of new horizons for aspiring journalists.

"There's no better time to get involved in journalism than now," said McIntire, "because of the confluence of issues that confront our country."

These issues may be related to the Trump era, but they transcend its bounds.

"This is really going to be a different kind of crucial time for journalists," agreed Shearer. She added that fissures in the Democratic and Republican parties and racial divides warrant attention as they continue to contribute to our country's divides.

Shearer envisions that contemporary movements for racial justice offer an opportunity for journalists to affect people's lives for the better. "There are a lot of people hurting in this country," she said, "and the best thing we can do is to keep asking: 'What's been done? What's been done to help?'"

"I think journalism's always been kind of a cool job, but I think people have gotten into their own kind of star power," said Carter, diagnosing an attitudinal problem that she admits having to keep in check herself.

Journalists should break news only when it serves the public good, according to Carter. "It's a job where if you're doing what's right, you're doing it because you feel that kind of sense—like, I gotta do something for this! You want to be the first one there."

Professor Shearer teaches students of journalism how to account for responsibility toward others when writing an article. "The first thing I would tell my students is, who are the other stakeholders on this? Who are the people we haven't thought about?"

Shearer acknowledged the conversation surrounding objectivity in journalism, but said that at the end of the day, "if you're only thinking of 'both' sides, you probably haven't thought enough. There's usually more than two sides to anything."

As the Trump-era fervor dies down, journalists hope that trust can be re-established and that the public can look toward the media with productive interest.

The answer may lie in local journalism.

"What's missing is local news reporting," concluded Carter emphatically. She, like McIntire, got her start reporting for local papers, and they both bemoaned the economic difficulties of journalism that have wiped out small and medium-sized newspapers.

Keeping apprised of local community leaders and the issues that affect individual states through local journalism is necessary, because people would know and care about what was happening in their own communities.

"I've always believed that being a journalist, your job is to be a voice for the voiceless," said Carter. Engagement with news at the local level would make a big difference, she explained, "because we'd have more voices."

Carter believes in the power of journalism, and she believes in her personal mission. "It's such a blessing to have this kind of job and to be able to do it," she reflected.

In truth, she said, "it's a service job."



Algorithmic Love

Should zeros and ones pick "the one?"

BY **KATHERINE CHOU**

"'Now you've got nothing left that's private, nothing that's yours and yours alone. Centillion owns all of you. You don't even know who you are anymore. You buy what Centillion wants you to buy; you read what Centillion suggests you read; you date who Centillion thinks you should date. But are you really happy?'

'That's an outdated way to look at it. Everything Tilly suggests to me has been scientifically proven to fit my taste profile, to be something I'd like.'"

"The Perfect Match" by Ken Liu

UNDER THE ROMANTIC SNOW flurries of a New Haven Valentine's Day, Datamatch's algorithm matched Yale students to either their true loves, most compatible friends, or someone else who signed up just for "shits and giggles."

Datamatch isn't quite Tilly, the all-knowing, match-making algorithm that controls everyone's lives in Ken Liu's short-story "The Perfect Match." It is, however, a reflection of the new role technology plays in our social lives, especially in the midst of a global pandemic that has inhibited in-person social interactions.

All algorithms are reflections of our desires: We want cars that drive themselves, predictable ways to make money in the stock market, and people to love who will love us back. But Ed Finn, founding director of the Center for Science and the Imagination (CSI) at Arizona State University, considers the allure of algorithms on a more fundamental level.

"There is a desire embedded in the whole idea of the algorithm itself, which is to make the whole world computable," he shared in an interview

with *The Politic*.

"We desperately want the answers, and we want to believe in the godlike, rational power of the machine," he continued. "We end up putting our faith in the machine [to a degree] that we don't even trust ourselves [nor do we] trust other humans."

Because of this desire to believe they can provide what humans cannot, algorithms are powerful—even when, mathematically, they aren't.

Datamatch doesn't need to become more accurate or feel more threatening for us to confront the underlying question of algorithms' role in social relationships. With Datamatch, as with other algorithmic programs, it's not truly about whether we'll create a more accurate version, or even if we should. It's about why we want to have a match-making algorithm, if we actually do want to have it, and what that means for our relationships with each other.

Finn founded CSI over a decade ago to be a space for science fiction writers, artists, scientists, engineers, and researchers to "come up with technically grounded, optimistic visions of the future [and] to start working together to create more inspiring visions."

Shaping our future is a concern in any era, but it is especially pressing in today's environment—where accessible and advancing technology accelerates innovation and grants any individual the power to affect the future. Everything, from casual student-made dating apps to government-funded algorithms, is reflective of what we want and what kind of future we are creating.

"...Ridiculous… Just the kind of pseudo-intellectual anti-technology rant that people like her mistake for profundity."

"The Perfect Match" by Ken Liu

IT MAY SEEM "PSEUDO-INTELLECTUAL" to draw connections between Datamatch and dystopian sci-fi stories, as if one might become the other. To the Yalie opening their email on an ordinary Sunday evening, Datamatch can seem more like a meme than a transformative cornerstone of change. You fill out a questionnaire, choosing which Yale library best represents you or describing your Wednesday night, and you don't expect anything serious to come from it.

Alice Mao '24 filled out her survey with this level of skepticism and levity. "I didn't really expect to find a soulmate there or anything. If I did actually really get along with somebody, then that would be like a bonus," she said.

Datamatch does not feel imposingly powerful because, unlike Liu's fictional algorithm Tilly, Datamatch is just a fallible, inconsequential pastime that is neither all-knowing nor all-powerful. Mao explained, "I can't imagine it being a long-term dating option. The charm is its novelty."

"The Perfect Match," like any other science fiction story, does not intend to predict the future or even depict a possible future. Rather, these stories give readers and writers a playground and vocabulary to imagine solutions, problems, changes, and reactions.

People are not pieces of a puzzle in which only two pieces fit together just right

Science fiction is a tool, Finn told *The Politic*, that is "uniquely positioned in this feedback loop between technological progress and our creative imagination."

"Imagination," he said, "is something that we tend to kind of ignore or take for granted until it goes missing. And then we lament failures of imagination."

In the midst of a pandemic and constant technological innovation, we are embroiled in a formative time of transformation, with our society wrestling with science, technology, and social change. Through sci-fi, Finn says, we can explore questions of "our hopes and fears about what we actually want to happen."

"As predicted, it turned out they were into the same books, the same movies, the same music. They had compatible ideas about how hard one should work. They laughed at each other's jokes. They fed off each other's energy.

Four billion women on Earth, and Tilly seemed to have found the perfect match for him."

"The Perfect Match" by Ken Liu

WHAT WE ACTUALLY WANT to happen when it comes to love and relationships is not a simple question. We consider emotions and social connections to be the very qualities that separate us from machines. And yet we also look to machines to guide us through romantic relationships.

Margaret Clark, a professor of psychology at Yale, wrote to *The Politic*, "People are not pieces of a puzzle in which only two pieces fit together just right. Rather, people come together, interact with one another, and the nature and feel of the relationships lies in the nature of that interaction. People adapt to one another and change as they do."

Dating—which has never been simple to begin with—is made even more complicated with the rise of the modern internet. "The availability of dating sites," Clark noted, "has widened the pool of possible partners by a lot." However, while a large proportion of romantic relationships in recent years have begun online, she emphasizes that "immediate, physical proximity still plays an important role in whom we meet and form relationships with."

In the past year, we have entered into somewhat of a social contradiction: Technology furnishes us with an expanded pool of people to interact with, but COVID-19 simultaneously depletes our relationships of the critical component of human interaction. Since last March, organic ways of falling in love have become not only inconvenient, but dangerous.

When it is difficult to navigate relationships ourselves, putting our faith in a system that can supposedly compute the correct answer is a seductive idea.

This algorithmic view, however, assumes something that Clark doesn't believe is true: that a perfect match exists, that "there really is one person or one precise type of person (with characteristics 1, 2, 3, 4, etc.) who is one's soulmate."

"I just don't think the soulmate idea makes sense. I think a wide variety of different types of pairings might be equally satisfying or good (or equally rotten)," she concluded.

"Although everything had gone exceedingly well, if he was being completely honest with himself, it wasn't quite as exciting and lovely as he had expected. Everything was indeed going smoothly, but maybe just a tad too smoothly. It was as if they already knew everything there was to know about each other. There were no surprises, no thrill of finding the truly new."

"The Perfect Match" by Ken Liu

EVEN IF WE HAD THE CAPACITY to create an algorithm with the accuracy of science fiction machines, do people actually want what algorithms for relationships promise? As American sociologist Edward O. Wilson once said, "the real problem of humanity is the following: we have paleolithic emotions; medieval institutions; and god-like technology." Perhaps we create technology before we truly understand our own desires.

In attempting to mathematize love, we overestimate what the algorithm can provide and underestimate what human variables can do.

Clark's lab conducts research on how emotional relationships unfold, and how people pursue the relationships they want. Self-promotion to a potential partner and self-protection from possible rejection are key components to how a person initiates a relationship. An algorithm promising an omnipotent perspective impacts this natural deliberation. Clark explained, "Your interest in another person may not be reciprocated and it's painful when that occurs. Believing that [the] use of an algorithm can prevent that might be reassuring to some people."

At the same time, some want the romanticized pain that heartbreaks, breakups, and unrequited loves bring—it can be pitfalls that make successful relationships all the more special. According to Meghan Laslocky, author of *The Little Book of Heartbreak*, "the pain is there to teach us something. It focuses our attention on significant social events and forces us to learn, correct, avoid, and move on." Other research supports the idea that breakups are seminal moments of growth.

Even for someone who wants to find the perfect relationship right away, Clark emphasized that a "fit" between partners is not binary. Partners adapt as they interact, and are influenced both by one another but external factors as well.

In attempting to mathematize love, we overestimate what the algorithm can provide and underestimate what human variables can do. People and relationships are ever-changing, making it impossible for an algorithm to capture enough information to determine a perfect match. When we expect an algorithm to give us both certainty and fluidity, we are, as Finn put it, "[bending] over backwards to make them seem more magical and powerful than they really are."

"Having Tilly around was like having the world's best assistant..."

"'You see? Without Tilly, you can't do your job, you can't remember your life, you can't even call your mother. We are now a race of cyborgs. We long ago began to spread our minds into the electronic realm, and it is no longer possible to squeeze all of ourselves back into our brains.'"

"The Perfect Match" by Ken Liu

ALGORITHMS ARE INGRAINED in nearly every aspect of our lives—search engines, social media, navigation tools, ads, college admissions, insurance, and even jail time. The image of dangerous algorithms taking over the world looks more mundane in reality than in novels, but it is no less significant.

Since Ada Lovelace created the first computer algorithm in 1843 to calculate the Bernoulli numbers, humans have worked to expand the reach of algorithms. Finn's 2017 book *What Algorithms Want* explains the advent and growth of algorithms in human society. The word "algorithm" and its modern meaning is founded on the notion of "effective computability"—when a question is solvable and has a knowable answer. If an outcome is effectively computable, the only thing to worry about is finding the answers, or creating algorithms with the computing power to find them. When Alan Turing, Alonzo Church, and other mathematicians first came up with algorithmic proofs in the mid-20th century, people were startled by how few questions were actually "solvable."

"From that time to this," Finn said, "what humans have worked to do is continually expand the space of effective computability, so that it now includes things like driving cars and piloting airplanes and telling you who to date."

We are always looking to expand our space of effective computability, because we want to know more about our world. However, having complex algorithms provide answers grants us an additional advantage as well: outsourcing decision-making, and thereby outsourcing culpability.

But devolving responsibility catches up to us. We still need to grapple with the implications of algorithms, romantic or otherwise, and determine who is accountable for the answers they compute, especially when those answers may encroach on our data and privacy or perpetuate biases and power imbalances.

"Everything Centillion did was arguably legal. The wireless transmissions were floating in public space, for example, so there was no violation of privacy. And the end user agreement could be read to allow everything Centillion did to 'make things better' for you."

"The Perfect Match" by Ken Liu

THE YEAR 2021 IS set to be a critical point for AI governance. Major developments are necessary: current regulation of algorithms in America is haphazard at best. Developers argue that their algorithms are neutral; they only become harmful because of biased data or

Having complex algorithms provide answers grants us an additional advantage as well: outsourcing decision-making, and thereby outsourcing culpability.

improper use by consumers, but users claim no responsibility because they don't understand the complicated, inscrutable workings of the technology they use.

Datamatch imagines the possibility of reinterpreting the nature of human relationships using technology. "The Perfect Match" imagines how people react—positively and negatively—in a world that has successfully reinterpreted that human-technology relationship.

Finn sees science fiction as a powerful equalizer: "The everyday general public, a roboticist, a poet, can all read the same science fiction story and have a really helpful discussion about our future and the technological and social possibilities of that future, without necessarily having to get graduate degrees or do a lot of research in preparation," he explained. "Setting out these possible futures as a shared space that leverages different kinds of expertise is really, really important as a way to make these futures more inclusive."

The technology we create in the present will shape the world we experience in the future. Before implementing technology that impacts our social interactions on a near molecular level, we need to answer questions about what we want from our social relationships. We need to imagine our future as we play with these "inconsequential" algorithms today.

Datamatch isn't a slippery-slope into an oppressive, controlling, algorithm-defined society, but it is an example of our desire to extend algorithms into social, emotional terrain. It is built into the idea of an algorithm that with its use, we can have a more straightforward world—one with more objective answers. But algorithms affect real people, and as we push them into new domains, they are forced to make decisions on increasingly intricate things. We make algorithms to give us answers, but behind every algorithm created to answer one question is a rabbit hole of deeper questions that algorithms cannot shoulder for us. When we want machines to "effectively compute" the decisions of our lives, questions about human desires and biases become all the more pressing to answer.

"'I never really thought of you as my type,' she said.

Sai's heart sank like a stone.

'But who thinks only in terms of 'types' except Tilly?' she said quickly, then smiled and pulled him closer."

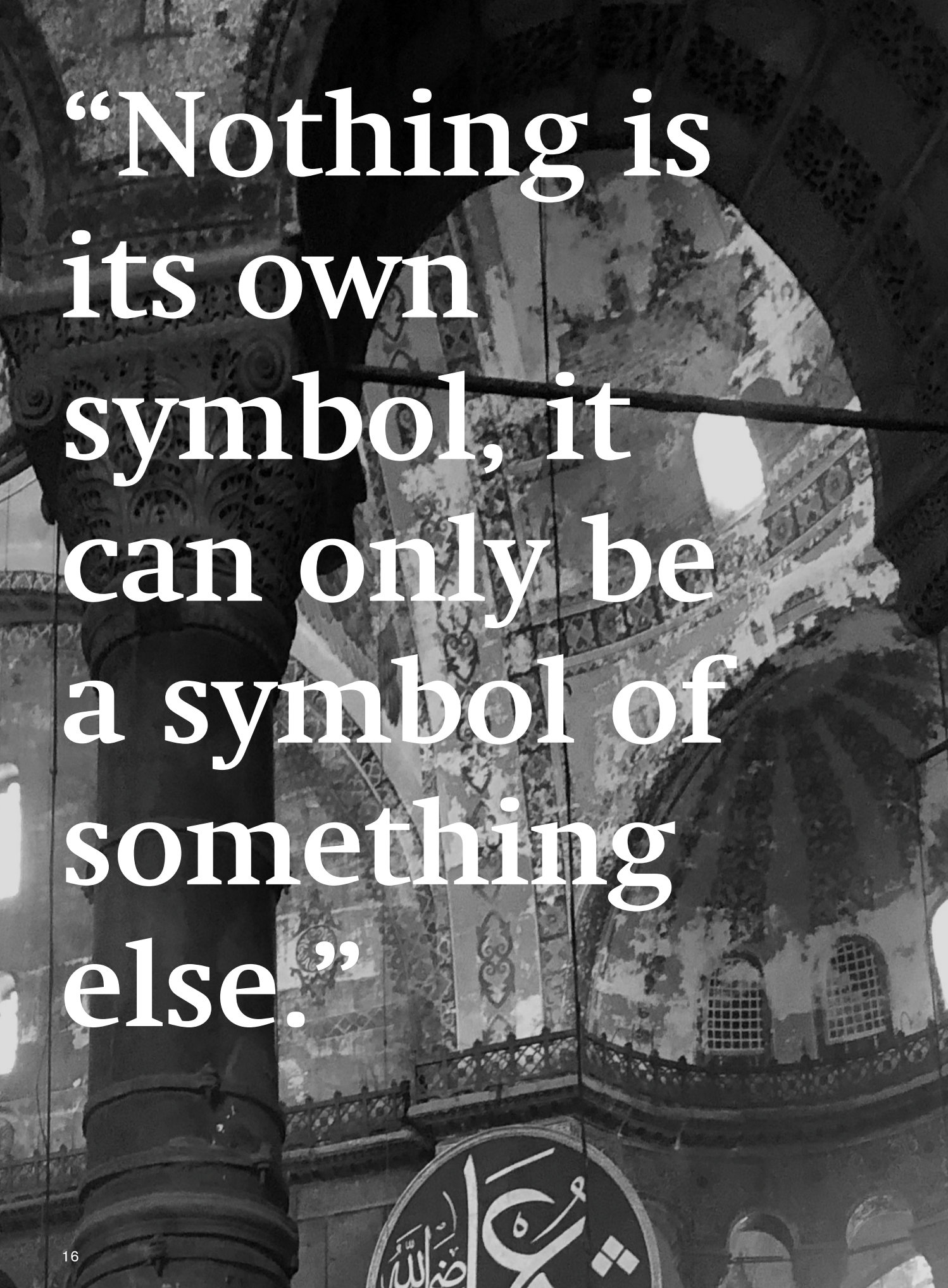
"The Perfect Match" by Ken Liu

DIVIDER SANCTUARY

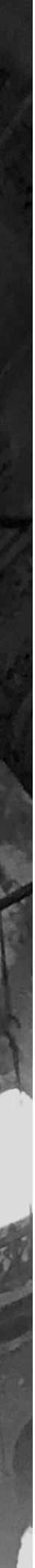
Claiming the Hagia Sophia, Turkey's religious battleground

BY **GAMZE KAZAKOGLU**

**All interviews were conducted in Turkish and translated by the author. Additionally, the pseudonym 'Alara Yildiz' has been used to protect a source's identity.*



“Nothing is its own symbol, it can only be a symbol of something else.”



ALARA YILDIZ FIRST visited the Hagia Sophia in 2018 for a school project while the building was in the midst of a major restoration. Scaffolding and barriers blocked movement throughout the structure and obscured views of the Hagia Sophia's interior walls. But it was not the monumental size of the structure that drew Yildiz's attention—she found herself fascinated by the Arabic calligraphy that traced a mosaic of the Virgin Mary.

"It seemed like a synthesis and union of Islam and Christianity. It was such an enchanting and special scene," she said in an interview with *The Politic*.

Now a 19-year-old college student in Istanbul, Yildiz is grateful to have visited Hagia Sophia back then despite her proximity to the ancient monument today, for she was able to visit before the building became a mosque and her feelings about its symbolism changed.

Yildiz, who refers to herself as an atheist, does not plan on visiting Hagia Sophia again.

On July 24, 2020, Turkish President Recep Erdogan announced that Istanbul's Hagia Sophia would be opened to *Salat*, Muslim prayers. Until then, the structure had been serving as a museum for 86 years.

Erdogan's conversion of the building from a secular museum to a mosque has sparked strong disagreement between different groups. Some Turkish Muslims largely expressed their delight, while many in the Orthodox Greek minority groups of Istanbul were fearful about what this decision signified for them, given the government's centuries-old attempts to suppress their community. While the Hagia Sophia will still be open to visitors of all faiths outside of prayer hours, this decision represents, to Turkey's Orthodox minority, a state-sanctioned hierarchy of Islam over Christianity.

Secular individuals felt that the reclassification constituted an attack on the liberal values of former president Mustafa Kemal Ataturk—who founded the new Turkish Republic from the ashes of the Ottoman Empire in 1923. Historians expressed hope that the government would preserve the historical monument artistically and architecturally in its new state.

Hagia Sophia has become a cultural touchstone, exemplifying the competing ideas about Turkey's past—and its future.

THE VERY NAME "Hagia Sophia" (*Ayasofya* in Turkish) is derived from the ancient Greek words *hagia* (sacred) and *sophia* (wisdom). Originally the largest church erected by the Eastern Roman Empire, the Hagia Sophia mosque that stands today is the building's third iteration, having been razed and rebuilt twice before. While there is not much information about the first structure, it was thought to have been constructed around 360 AD by the then-patriarch of the city, Saint Johannes Khyrsostomos, under the name "Great Church" (*Megali Ekklesia*). A later, second renovation occured in 415 AD under the reign of Emperor Theodosius of Constantinople, but it was destroyed just a century later during the notorious Nika Revolts. It was not until more than 100 years later in 532 AD that Byzantine Emperor Justinian funded construction on the building, which is referred to as the Hagia Sophia today.

Art historian Hayri Fehmi Yilmaz, who specializes in Byzantine art, emphasized Hagia Sophia's unique harmony of two distinct architectural traditions: The building features a Byzantine dome-shaped church as well as a wooden-roofed basilica.

"[The Hagia Sophia] has neither a predecessor nor a successor. Byzantines were so affected by the structure [that] they thought it was shaped by divine inspiration," Yilmaz said in an interview with *The Politic*. "Hagia Sophia is a structure that probably has one of the most legends about it. There is the structure which is studied by experts in art history and architecture, but the Hagia Sophia is also importantly the source of dreams and legends—and because of that many folks have come to consider the building as almost sacred."

Yorgo Istefanopulos, a professor at Işık University and the president of two Greek Orthodox foundations in Istanbul, is aware of many centuries-old folktales concerning the building. Some relate to the early construction of the third Hagia Sophia: Emperor Justinian was apparently so impressed with the church when he first saw it that he famously exclaimed, "I've beaten you, Solomon!"—considering the glory and opulence of the Hagia Sophia to exceed even that of the First Temple in Jerusalem.

Another myth claims that the Hagia Sophia was designed by a bee. A priest was in the midst of providing a piece of wine bread to Emperor Justinian during Christmas Day Communion when a bee stole the piece of bread. With the divine inspiration imparted through Communion, the bee was able to dream up the majestic structure of Hagia Sophia back in its hive.

Although these folktales form an important basis for Turkish society's understanding of and relationship to the Hagia Sophia, Sedat Bornovali, an art historian and the president of the Istanbul Chamber of Tourist Guides, considers the myth-constructed perception of Hagia Sophia to blind citizens' vision of the building. These legends, he believes, hamper any ability to recognize the building's historical and architectural importance.

Bornovali was the first expert in 86 years to suggest the continuation of archeological excavations in Hagia Sophia. Although President Ataturk approved of excavations on the Hagia Sophia in the early 20th century, no one has thought to continue the endeavor since—despite the rich history and artifacts that likely lie under the Hagia Sophia today. The logistics of the excavations also would have been simple to facilitate, given Hagia Sophia's proximity to the Istanbul Archeology Museum in the Fatih District of the city.

According to Bornovali, peo-

ple's tendencies to mythologize Hagia Sophia preclude deeper analysis of its history. Different ethnic and religious groups consider the Hagia Sophia only as it is situated within their own ideological framework: Devout Muslims and Christians prioritize spiritual legends while secular supporters assert the building's technological and architectural superiority and minimize its significance both to Chrisitianity and to Islam. As a result, the perception of the monument is inextricable from bias.

For Bornovali, the projection of competing religious beliefs on Hagia Sophia obfuscates its historical significance. While each group claims to promote an objective interpretation of the structure, for Bornovali, "Nothing is its own symbol, it can only be a symbol of something else."

But then again, the true meaning of Hagia Sophia has always been political, warped by overlapping religious and cultural narratives. When Romans invaded Constantinople after the Fourth Crusade in the 13th century, both the city and the Hagia Sophia, as Constantinople's largest church, were looted, and the Hagia Sophia became a Catholic church for a short time. After the Fall of Constantinople (also known as the conquest of Istanbul) in 1453, Fatih Sultan Mehmet converted it into a mosque that also housed a charity foundation (*külliye*).

The building's consistent conversion from religion to religion is almost "an ancient medieval practice," according to Yilmaz. "Whoever conquers the city also acquires the biggest sanctuary of the city.... You don't only get the city, but you also get all of its structures, too."

Often redesigned and reedified throughout its history, the Hagia Sophia naturally has become an inspiration for Ottoman art.

"Whenever someone says a 'mosque' in the Ottoman and Turkey geographies, the mosque image that pops up in their minds looks similar to Hagia Sophia—a mosque with a large dome and semi-domes," Yilmaz continued. "To Muslims, Hagia Sophia has become a symbol for mosques."

The Hagia Sophia continued to operate as a mosque from 1453 until 1934, when Ataturk ordered that the Hagia Sophia be turned into a museum. Ataturk's conversion epitomized the secular reforms that the leader passed as he sought to build a Western, European-facing Turkey. Many Muslims interpreted this decision as a direct attack on Islam and the religion's role in Turkish society. Since 1934, though, no leader has sought to change Hagia Sophia's status as a museum, with the building included on UNESCO's list of World Heritage sites and remaining one of the most popular tourist sites in Turkey.

That is, until Erdogan's right-leaning government chose to break with Ataturk's legacy last year and decided to convert the building back into a mosque.

Turkey joined the North Atlantic Treaty Organization (NATO) in 1952, serving as a palisade against Soviet expansion into the Mediterranean. While the country was considered "Western" enough to join NATO, the Republic's decade-long battle to join the European Union in 1987 ended in 2019 when accession negotiations officially ended over outrage about Turkey's human rights record. With Turkey unable to orient itself closer to Europe, Erdogan has quietly strengthened ties with Russia and China, like many other countries in the Middle East.

Following the structure's reclassification, the Erdogan administration laid a turquoise carpet down over the floors for prayers, concealing Byzantine mosaics with curtains once again—even though they were on public display until late 1740s under the officially Islamist Ottoman rule.

"Because these images inhibit Islamic prayers, they are now concealed behind a curtain. It is always possible to open these curtains and see the imagery, but it is forbidden to have this imagery and depiction in Islam," Mehmet Boynukalin, one of the three appointed imams of Hagia Sophia, said.

For now, Erdogan's government has agreed to protect the Christian art. Yet, as the new mosque draws criticism from international leaders, the new religious symbolism of Hagia Sophia remains disputed.

FOR INDIVIDUALS LIKE Yildiz, Erdogan's decision is not only a symbolic threat toward the European Union, but a masked threat to Greek and Orthodox Christian communities in Turkey as well.

"It seems like he's saying 'I don't care about you. We can turn Hagia Sophia into a mosque, do whatever we want, and you can't interfere with us,'" Yildiz said.

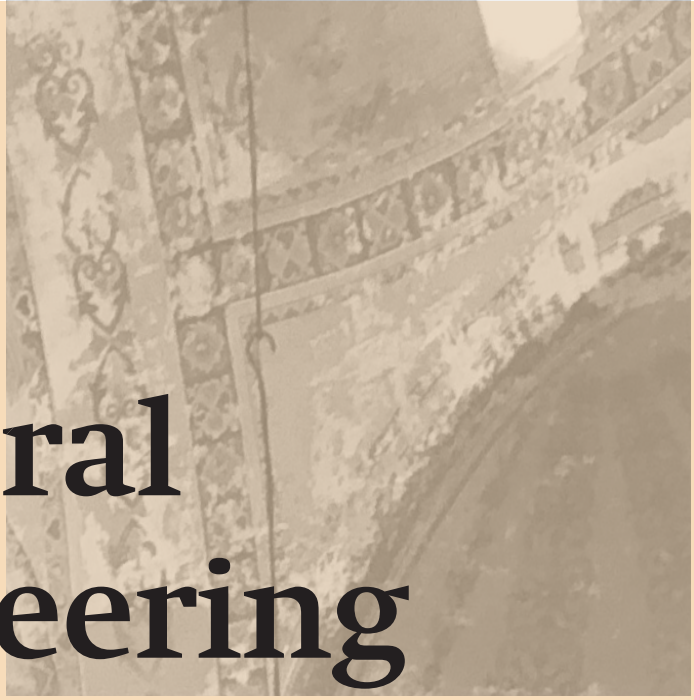
But for many practicing Muslims in Turkey, the decision to return the Hagia Sophia to its roots as a mosque corrects, as Ergodan has explained, Ataturk's initial "mistake" of converting the mosque into a monument. The conversion from a museum to a mosque aligns with Erdogan's consistent efforts to shift Turkey from Ataturk's secular legacy to a deepened, conservative Islamist identity.

And yet critics of the decision—and of the Erdogan government—have interpreted the reclassification of Hagia Sophia as having little basis in religion: Rather, they argue that it is meant to distract and placate Turkey's Muslim majority as the Erdogan government struggles to respond to the COVID-19 pandemic.

It seems though that if this was Erdogan's goal, he has failed.

The situation has further enhanced the longstanding tensions between liberal Kemalists, conservative Muslims, and Turkey's Orthodox Greek minority. Historians, however, have taken this time to look at the event through a different lens and as an opportunity to reexamine Hagia Sophia's history.

"It was a Christian temple for around 900 years, and a mosque for about half of this time. It is an architectural and engineering miracle which



"It is an architectural and engineering miracle which belongs to the whole world"

belongs to the whole world," Istefanopulos said.

Years ago, when a journalist from *Daily Sabah* interviewed Istefanopulos about the Greek minority community and the activities of their charity foundations, Istefanopulos was asked his thoughts on Hagia Sophia. While the question was unexpected, Istefanopulos shared his appreciation of Ataturk's move towards secularization. But he also suggested it could be opened to prayers four times a year—on Easter and Christmas for Christians, and on Eid al-Adha and Eid al-Fitr for Muslims.

Speaking on behalf of the Orthodox Greeks, Istefanopulos explained that the presence of the Arabic roundels inscribed to *Allah*, *Muhammed*, and *Hussein*, among other Arabic inscriptions, would not impact the Hagia Sophia's potential utilization as a church.

Istefenapulos also thinks the structure's global orientation is crucial for the country's tourism income: "After it was added to the World Heritage List of UNESCO in 1934 and converted to a museum, Hagia Sophia became one of the most significant contributors to Turkey's tourism economy," Istefanopulos said. "Yet that will not be the case anymore. As of right now, no one is paying to enter the mosque."

But Boynukalin views the novelty of free entrance to the building as an advantage. For him, not being obliged to pay has made the structure more accessible to the masses.

"The visitor numbers are increasing, because anyone who wants to can now enter Hagia Sophia without paying anything," Boynukalin told *The Politic* in an email correspondence. "Although it used to be silent and dark, Hagia Sophia is now awakened and has returned to its true identity as a ritual site."

Boynukalin felt honored when the Directorate of Religious Affairs offered him a position as an imam. For him, being a religious leader in such a historically significant sanctuary was a source of great happiness.

"As an indicator of secularism and westernization, Hagia Sophia—the greatest and the most beautiful mosque of the now Muslim city of Istanbul—was closed down and turned into a museum in 1934," Boynukalin said. "After 86 years of unending demands from the public, Hagia Sophia has regained its identity as a mosque."

For Yildiz, however, Hagia Sophia opening its doors to the masses has overshadowed critical public health measures aimed to prevent the spread of COVID-19.: "Following news of the building opening for prayer, a lot of people came from around the world:

From Pakistan, from America, from everywhere," Yildiz said. "It has posed a big threat to public health in Istanbul." *Salat*, and particularly Friday Prayers (*Salat al-Jumu'ah*), often draw hundreds of people to their local mosques: During the pandemic, gatherings of this size are considered dangerous.

Yet while Friday Prayers initially drew large and enthusiastic crowds, from what Bornovali observed, the initial excitement has worn off over the past months.

According to Bornovali, the dwindling crowds reveal a deeper truth: Istanbul actually carries no historical importance for either Christianity or Islam despite contemporary discourse to the contrary. As such, Hagia Sophia does not embody a particular religious significance for either of the religions.

"What is Hagia Sophia a symbol of? The symbol is in the possession of the Hagia Sophia. Of acquiring it from someone else," Bornovali said. Istanbul, and the Hagia Sophia with its imposing views of the Bosphorus Strait—which divides Asia from Europe—has long been seized, looted, and rebuilt by generations of Christians and Muslims.

Byzantine Christians constructed the initial structure and its iterations, Romans seized it for Catholicism, and later Muslims laid claim to Hagia Sophia through a famous hadith, or saying, by the prophet Muhammed: "One day Constantinople will be conquered. Great is the commander who will conquer it. Great are his soldiers."

Many Islamic scholars deny the accuracy of the hadith attribution to the Prophet Muhammed, but according to Yildiz, Muslims—whether Turkish or non-Turkish—feel empowered by the thought that Istanbul finally belongs to them.

"Hagia Sophia was the last remaining monument as a peace symbol between Muslim Turks and Orthodox Christians. Now that the conversion is made, it is a source of sadness for the Greek minorities as much as it is a source of happiness for Muslim Turks," Yildiz explained.

According to Yilmaz, Muslims have long viewed the Hagia Sophia as emblematic of the Ottoman victory over Christians following the Fall of Constantinople. Ever since the Hagia Sophia and Constantinople (now known as Istanbul) came under the control of Islamic rulers, Muslims have interpreted this as a manifestation of *Allah*'s will.

In that sense, Hagia Sophia has served as a symbol of Byzantine Christianity, Ottoman Islam, and of the Republic of Turkey's 20th century secularization. For art historians like Bornovali and Yilmaz, determining how the structure should operate today is complicated by its diverse background and meanings to different groups.

For those Muslims now practicing at the mosque, the building's historical and religious underpinnings are not mutually exclusive."The fact that the building is now a mosque does not prevent any useful and necessary excavation from taking place," Boynukalin emphasized. Still, historians like Bornovali fear that with the Hagia Sophia's new status as a mosque, contemporary efforts to both encourage artistic and architectural preservation as well as explore the mosque's complicated religious history will stagnate.

ON A BROADER LEVEL, the debate over Hagia Sophia epitomizes the ongoing clash between the "East"—denoting those areas that belong to the former Islamic Empire—and the "West"—Christian Europe. It reflects Turkey's centuries-old identity crisis to posit itself on that spectrum. Debates over Hagia Sophia's meaning reveal a national identity in flux.

During her visit to Hagia Sophia in high school, Yildiz was fascinated by the dichotomy of Byzantine mosaics alongside Arabic letters and what this juxtaposition revealed about the structure's significance. For Yildiz, Hagia Sophia's importance does not lie in whether it is a church or a mosque. Rather, Hagia Sophia is important because it is a synthesis of the two.

"If you don't see the [Byzantine] mosaics—or, if they removed Arabic letters—Hagia Sophia would no longer carry its symbolic importance," Yildiz said.

In Turkey, despite religious polarization between Muslim Turks and Orthodox Christians, both groups share a common heritage that has been shaped by the marriage of European and Middle Eastern influences in the country.

This leaves Turkey with a heavy responsibility: Commemorating the Hagia Sophia as a shared cultural inheritance for all ethnic and religious sects while preserving identity groups' individual claims to the landmark site.

Amid centuries of chaotic transformation, Istanbulis have managed to protect the building to this day. Perhaps Yilmaz summarized this change in the best way: "Atheist, religious Muslim, religious Orthodox, secular, secular Muslim, or secular Orthodox…. It doesn't matter. It is the duty of all us to preserve the building with all of its elements."





CONCRETE DREAMS

One hotel portends a new future for Long Wharf

BY **EMILY TIAN**

I SAW THE PIRELLI BUILDING for the first time, like many, while driving northbound on I-95, en route to Yale. The building's poured concrete facade shades somewhere between gray and beige, depending on the hour. Its 216 highway-facing windows throw their gaze beyond the 150,000 vehicles rushing by the interstate each day, beholding instead the water that edges around the city, which mixes and meets as one small divot of the Long Island Sound.

It is a building of nine floors—or no, six, maybe seven—depending on how you count.

The counting confusion is caused by the absence of a third or fourth floor. The building vaults upwards from the second to the fifth, leaving a couple steel and concrete trusses in the place of a continuous facade. It is too massive of a structure to delude you into believing in its weightlessness: the suspension act appears more Atlas-like than acrobatic.

The absence of these floors creates all sorts of illusive effects: from a certain angle, New Haven comes into view in the gap.

For over 50 years, like a camera held in half-shutter, the monument has framed a changing city. But after sitting empty for more than half its lifetime, the Pirelli Building will reopen this fall as a new hotel.



There's an idea using common material but levitati

WHAT IS NOW KNOWN as the Pirelli Tire Building was completed in 1969 by Marcel Breuer, a celebrated modernist furniture designer and architect of the Bauhaus School whose body of work includes the recently-closed Met Breuer in New York, the Boca Raton IBM, and Yale's own Becton Engineering and Applied Science Center on Prospect Street.

Breuer was brought onto the project at the behest of Mayor Richard C. Lee, whose urban renewal program dominated New Haven's mid-century planning and development. Already a celebrated architect, Breuer was responsible not only for designing a functional office and research facility for the Armstrong Rubber Company but also a dramatic urban landmark to symbolize a new, aspirational city.

Armstrong Rubber did not need nine or ten floors of office space for its new headquarters in Long Wharf, New Haven's waterfront district, but Lee hoped to use their move as an opportunity to inaugurate a city symbol. In a letter to Marcel Breuer dating to February 24, 1966, Lee wrote, "New Haven for more than a decade has been engaged in an urban development program which is unmatched anywhere in America.... The list of architects who have built in New Haven reads like a 'Who's-who' of the architectural profession."

Breuer's levitating floors responded not only to the public vision Lee promoted but also to the functional needs of the privately held company: The sometimes noisy or noxious effects of researching and developing rubber products could be contained within the lower two floors, while the upper stories, used for office space, were sealed by a natural sound barrier. The building, New Haven officials hoped, would draw in passersby from the newly constructed highway into the city proper; it was also a towering symbol of a flourishing automotive industry as car production boomed.

However, the city over which Breuer's building stood vigil never quite became the "model" that officials and planners had envisioned.

Lee's plan to redevelop New Haven amid industrial losses and economic stagnation included pursuing massive infrastructural projects with state and federal backing that cleared "slums" and displaced thousands of low-income residents—trauma that abides even today in many New Haven neighborhoods.

50 years past his tenure, many of the original aspirational structures commissioned during the Lee era have been demolished or neglected.

Despite its architectural significance, the Pirelli Building, too, was not immune to industrial decline. In 1988, Armstrong Rubber, once the fifth largest tire manufacturer in the world, was bought out by Pirelli, an Italian multinational tire company, who opted to leave the New Haven site unused. The building passed hands again in 2003 from Pirelli to the Swedish furniture conglomerate IKEA, whose own blue building squats next to Breuer's.

"There's an idea behind this building—using common materials for ordinary people but levitating them [and] making dreams out of the mud," Laura Wexler, Yale Professor of American Studies and Women's, Gender, and Sexuality Studies, said in an interview with *The Politic*. Wexler, who first moved to New Haven in the 1970s, has watched the Pirelli Building accumulate new meanings as it has aged.

"The Pirelli Building symbolizes a deep history of New Haven.... It was aspirational and failed," Wexler said.

IN THE PAST 20 YEARS, the Pirelli Building has served occasionally as a facade for IKEA billboards and as a temporary art exhibition space, its post-industry afterlife reamed



a behind this building—
s for ordinary people
ng them [and]
making dreams out of
the mud

somewhere between corporate convenience and spectral reminders of its past.

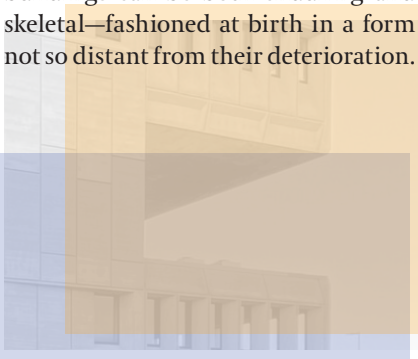
The box-like structure that presides over Sargent Drive is actually a severed version of Breuer's building. In 2003, in the face of vocal opposition from preservationists, IKEA (which, ironically, has inherited aspects of Bauhaus and modernist design) demolished much of the building's extended horizontal base, shearing it down to the length of the suspended tower, in order to create more parking space for their newly-opened warehouse next door. Its long reclining torso—which contributed to an essential "formal asymmetry" in the building, according to one preservationist—was replaced by parking asphalt.

It was this amputation that most interested the New Haven-native artist Tom Burr, who leased the ground floor of the building for a year in 2017 to present a site-specific installation drawing from local history. Telling news outlets at the time that he wasn't there to save the building, Burr draped a symbolic white banner across the building's sutured wall, at once recalling both a bandage and a billboard.

The decline of the Pirelli Building was in part owed to limited public appreciation for Brutalist architecture, of which the Pirelli is an iconic exemplar. The *Business Insider* readership, in 2018, notably crowned it the "ugliest" building in Connecticut.

Brutalism comes out of the French term *Béton brut*, or "raw concrete." For many post-war architects, unfinished, frequently prefabricated concrete heralded a doing-away of excess ornamentation; it stood for authenticity, functionality, and populism. In concrete, architects found a highly expressive material that could be manipulated into near-sculptural forms.

With their frequently exposed frames and cantilevers, Brutalist buildings can be both enduring and skeletal—fashioned at birth in a form not so distant from their deterioration.



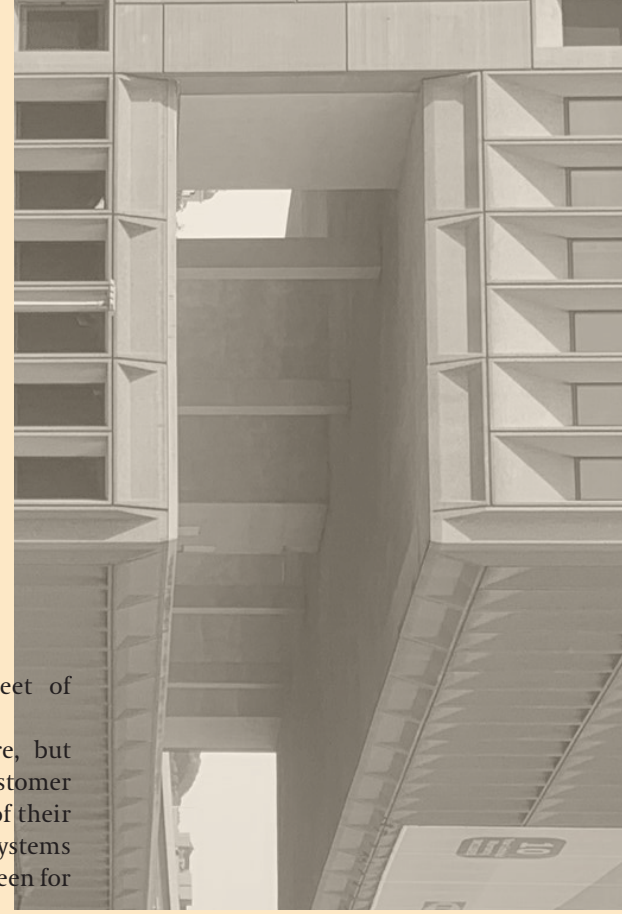
Despite its partial demolition, conversations about permanently adapting the space into a new role have percolated for years. In November of 2018, hoping to sell off the property, IKEA won approval from city planners for its plan to convert the unused building into a hotel without changing the building's exterior. Following a series of negotiations, the then-owners brokered a deal with the development firm Becker and Becker, who bought the building for 1.2 million dollars at the end of 2019. Hotel Marcel, a 165 room boutique hotel named for its pioneering architect, will operate under the Hilton Tapestry label. Construction for the Marcel began amid the pandemic last summer and is currently projected to be completed around November of 2021.

BRUCE BECKER is a familiar name to many in New Haven: just over ten years ago, his firm developed 360 State Street, the 500-unit apartment complex also occupied by Elm City Market on its ground floor. 360 State—the largest apartment building in the state and the second tallest building in New Haven—also broke ground as the first residential complex in the state to earn a LEED-Platinum designation for energy and environmental design. Many of the other projects in his portfolio feature adaptive reuse of historic sites and sustainable design in residential and mixed-use developments.

"I don't know of any building as captivating architecturally as that building," Becker, a graduate of the Yale School of Architecture, said in an interview with *The Politic*. "I hope that I'm not just fixing up one building but repairing something with a greater impact in the city."

Although the building is not yet open to the public, Becker's portfolio and the project's funding sources—a 25 million dollar permanent loan from Liberty Bank and a blend of various state and federal tax credits—

ordinary people
out of the mud



both suggest that the development will carefully attend to its history while breaking new ground in sustainable design.

Since the building is listed in the Connecticut Register of Historic Places, Becker's development project qualifies for historic tax credits, a federal incentive to rehabilitate older buildings by lowering an owner's tax liability. To remain eligible, the hotel is held to a set of historical preservation standards that will ensure that the exterior of the hotel will conform to the existing building envelope.

A handful of years ago, mid-century structures would hardly have been considered worthy of historic preservation. The building's aesthetic beauty may be contested, preservationists say, but not its history.

"If we were to tear down everything that wasn't objectively beautiful, we would be missing a lot of our history," Elizabeth Holt, director of the New Haven Preservation Trust, said in an interview with *The Politic*. "A building that incites questioning is worthy of saving."

By restoring the building as an operable hotel, developers are warding off the prospect of demolition.

"The building now has a new purpose, and to survive it has to change," Violette de La Selle, a Yale School of Architecture graduate who has worked closely with Becker on the hotel, said to *The Politic*.

Guided by Becker's "passion for sustainability," the hotel is projected to be one of the most sustainable in the country and the first nationwide to meet the Passive House certification, an energy efficiency standard widely accredited in Europe.

The building is supposed to generate enough renewable energy on-site through rooftop and parking canopy solar panels to fully power its facilities and operations. Traditionally high energy-expending laundry services and hotel kitchens will also be electrically powered, and Becker suggested that the hotel shuttle service will incorporate a fleet of electric vehicles.

"The technology is there, but although hotels do more customer marketing and greenwashing of their eco-friendly amenities, their systems remain the same as they have been for decades," Becker said.

Hotel Marcel's sustainable design framework radiates naturally from the building's existing frame. The building's deep set windows reduce energy expenditure by shading the building in the summer and bringing in passive heat when the sun is low in the sky. And, most fundamentally, Becker added, "The greenest building is the one you don't have to build from scratch."

THE HOTEL RENOVATION has created over 100 construction jobs, and another 40 permanent employees—many which may be union—are expected to be hired once the hotel opens. It may seem quixotic that the project persists while a pandemic has knocked the hospitality industry to its knees. Extended furloughs hit over 150 hospitality workers at the Omni Hotel in downtown New Haven, one of the city's largest luxury hotels. During peak losses last April, employment in Connecticut's leisure and hospitality industry was down by 54.5 percent compared to years prior. As of February of 2021, 13.5 percent of the industry's workers are still unemployed—significantly more than most industries, according to the Bureau of Labor Statistics.

However, in the years before the pandemic, hotel occupancy rates in New Haven hovered around 70 percent, edging out nationwide averages by several points. These numbers, Becker said, demonstrate that pre-pandemic New Haven was still underserved.

Of course, whether the industry will—or if it can, at all—recoup the losses of the past year remains as of yet unclear. But Becker, more than most, has reason to be confident in the hotel's success.

More than a decade ago, floors for his 360 State Street building were going up while the city still rocked from the 2008 economic recession. "I knew we were going to be okay as a city when I saw that building was still going up," Doug Hausladen, a longtime resident of New Haven and the city's transportation and traffic director, said.

With the Hotel Marcel projected to open as New Haven experiences a multi-year boom in boutique hotels, Becker is certainly not the first to observe the New Haven hospitali-

ty sector's potential for growth. In a cluster of hotels already populated by the Study and the Courtyard Marriott, the historic Duncan Hotel was opened as the Graduate New Haven in the fall of 2019, followed swiftly by The Blake on High Street.

Lauren Zucker, the Associate Vice President for New Haven Affairs at Yale, told *The Politic* that the Pirelli is a "welcome addition to the growing New Haven hospitality market."

Slightly farther afield from the downtown neighborhood of boutique hotel developments, Hotel Marcel, in theory, carves out a slimmer market of Yale visitors—Becker speculated that Yale-affiliated guests might constitute less than half of their clientele—but could draw from a more diverse market of conference-goers, medical visitors of the Yale New Haven Hospital system, and those intrigued by the building's architectural history or sustainable design. The hotel's affiliation with Hilton may also claim some customers loyal to the major operator brand.

In the long term, Becker is wagering on the prospect of a symbiotic relationship between the hotel and Long Wharf's natural resources and neighboring sites. One 15-floor corporate office building, the Long Wharf Maritime Center, houses multiple biotechnology companies; education consulting, technology, and financial firms are filling up an office tower nearby.

"It would be great to get the hotels and restaurants from an academic calendar to a 12-month one," said Hausladen.

Hausladen speculates that more conferences and waterfront activities might bring visitors to New Haven year-round, in contrast to the usual slow burn of the summer months.

Just steps from the site of the hotel, the chic, glassy, 43 million dollar Canal Dock Boathouse—a multi-use 30,000 square foot facility that opened in 2018—may be an especially auspicious partner. The Boathouse, which serves the community with boating and kayaking activities and education initiatives, also doubles as an event or conference venue.

Plans to increase the connectivity between Long Wharf and Union Station—through an anticipated construction of a new tunnel directly linking the edge of the district to the railway—would also improve access to the site from New Haven's central transit hub.

In the coming years, recreational travelers may flock in larger numbers to Long Wharf following the completion of the Farmington Canal Greenway, a popular biking and walking canal-turned-trail that winds from New Haven to Northampton, MA. The trail currently ends on Temple Street, tucked under Benjamin Franklin College, but the final phase of the project—planned sometime for the next several years—is expected to bring the trail through Wooster Square toward Long Wharf Pier.

The Hotel Marcel has the potential to become an important steward of its surrounding ecosystem, relying on local recreational resources and infrastructure to attract guests while itself also reanimating interest in Long Wharf.

WHAT IS TODAY Long Wharf is a palimpsest of its earlier forms. In 1890, a railroad company purchased the historic commercial wharf, terracing over northern segments of the wharf to expand its freight tracks. Decades later, the Connecticut State Highway Department decided to use the parcel of land and surrounding area to expand U.S. Route 1. After the harbor was dredged for highway construction, a redevelopment project carried out by the New Haven Redevelopment Agency in the mid-1960s transformed the infill into a district of horizontally sprawling plants and a recreational waterfront park.

"The story of urban renewal is a traumatic and very painful story for neighborhoods that were destroyed to make way for vision of the city they weren't a part of," said Professor Elihu Rubin, Yale Associate Professor of Architecture and Assistant Professor of American Studies, in an interview with *The Politic*.

Rubin explained that the parceled, industrial landscape of Long Wharf arose in part out of the city's desperate competition with the suburbs and its "concern for the obsolescence of the city center amid the automobile age." Newly filled in from highway construction, Long Wharf became such a site to create "suburban style" industrial parcels in the city.

Since those parcels were created

on highway infill, Rubin said that Long Wharf is spared some of the "darker narratives associated with urban renewal structures downtown, because there was no direct displacement [of local residents]." But, Rubin added, "it remains a part of a broader narrative of reconstructing the city, and a lament to what had been sacrificed and lost."

Although Long Wharf is currently non-residential, it is hugged by downtown New Haven and the Wooster Square neighborhood from the north and by the Hill, a mostly working-class and minority community from the west. Bearing signs of its industrial history, Long Wharf is today perhaps most beloved for its public parks, the regional nonprofit Long Wharf Theatre, and the Latin American food trucks that line Long Wharf Drive.

"Long Wharf is for everybody. New Haven is really neighborhood-centric, but Long Wharf means different things for different people," said Aicha Woods, the City of New Haven's City Plan Executive Director.

Unlike decades ago, when then-Mayor Lee played matchmaker between Marcel Breuer's firm and Armstrong Rubber, the city government today has little steering power in the development of Hotel Marcel. But officials have for years been eyeing ways to reclaim Long Wharf as a vibrant public space.

In the spring of 2019, city officials debuted the Long Wharf Responsible Growth Plan, a 100-page vision to build out the 352-acre waterfront which is currently separated from surrounding neighborhoods by the interstate.

But since New Haven is just under 20 square miles, there are a limited number of ways that the city can develop without directly displacing existing communities. Long Wharf, non-residential and under-utilized, is a linchpin of New Haven's vision of growth, Carlos Eyzaguirre, the City's Economic Development Officer, shared with The Politic.

Undertaking this vision will be neither fast or cheap—redeveloping Long Wharf in line with the plan, which breaks down Long Wharf into five walkable, mixed-use districts linked by a new greenway, would cost well over 100 million dollars in public spending and is intended to guide planning and development decisions over the next 20 years.

These five neighborhoods will each be anchored in distinct, but connected, sites or themes: gateway, innovation, market, parkway, and harbor. In total, the plan encompasses more than 7.7 million square feet of new development, including 4,600 residential units—assuming that the district will be rezoned to permit mixed and affordable housing development. The ambitious planned redevelopment is set to pump over an average of 600 construction jobs into the economy every year amid the development process, and ultimately support around 3,500 jobs once the district is fully realized.

The ribbon of greenway and pockets of parkland that the project proposes are set up not only to open up the district to pedestrians and cyclists but also as a natural stormwater flood barrier. Incorporating recommendations from a 2017 Flood Protection study of Long Wharf, which observed that the coastal area is highly vulnerable to flooding, the plan proposes a raised pedestrian walkway along the waterfront that can double as a living shoreline.

"Our city suffered a great loss when its water access was cut off by the construction of the highway," Lior Tresman, an avid cyclist who is a member of the New Haven Safe Streets Coalition, wrote in an email to The Politic. "Any effort to reconnect the city to the water would in my mind be great progress."



IT SEEMS FITTING that concrete—the material used to lay down roads—is transposed onto the Pirelli building's monumental face. Were it not for the post-war car frenzy and highway construction that shot the automotive industry to new heights, the tires that spun out of the manufacturing line at Armstrong Rubber may never have been designed in the first place.

Without the interstate, it's hard

to imagine why Armstrong Rubber would find a home in a seven (or nine) floor concrete building on a small parcel of coastal New Haven to perfect the sticky and noxious practice of tire making.

The twin history of the hotel and the highways is rife with complications: when highways barrelled through New Haven, they directly displaced nearly 900 families, flattened and severed poor and minority neighborhoods from downtown, and cut the waterfront from the rest of the city. They also helped inaugurate new, sprawling suburbs, traversable by car, as an attractive alternative to urban life — spurring white flight that contributed to population decline and drained the city's tax base.

If the Pirelli were to serve as the gateway to a new, modern, progressive city, its emptiness and near-demolition suggested that Mayor Lee's vision of building a model city through urban renewal had failed. Weathered but generally resistant to ruin, concrete Brutalism offered a modernist account of functionality and durability—to "cement" something is to endue it with permanence. But the afterlife of the Pirelli as a buzzy, sustainable hotel, in direct contrast to its rubber-making history, suggests that the building can only endure if it is reconceived.

"We can read the landscape and see it as a result of choices made and lost," Wexler said. "Bruce [Becker] isn't trying to repair that. Despite this history, we can also go forward: nothing prevents us from having this, too."

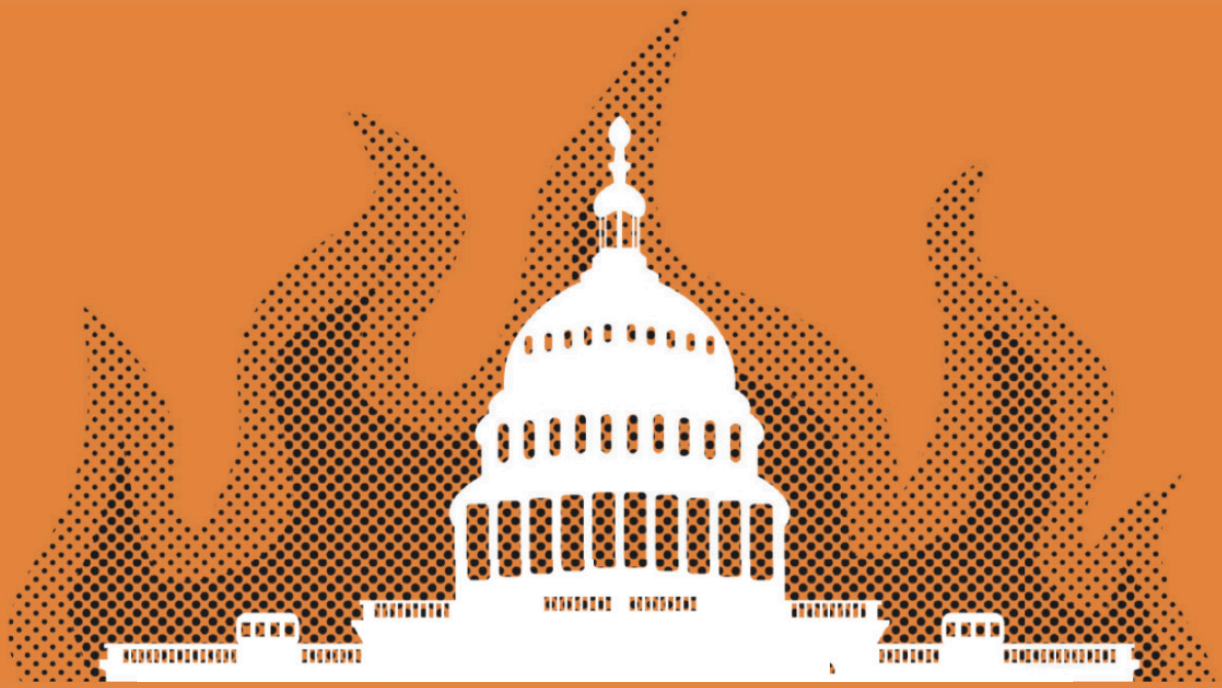
Right off the highway shoulder, a mile from Union Station, and minutes from the boats and bikes, the Marcel may now be able to use the interstate to draw visitors into the city where it had once driven them out. While New Haven sheds its industrial past in favor of a growing service sector, Becker's office building-turned-hotel relates New Haven's mid-century urbanist history to a visionary plan for Long Wharf.

"The coming two decades are all about the Long Wharf district and, broadly, the water," said Hausladen. "The water is a problem and a solution for so many things."

Earlier this month, I took a sunrise walk down to the Long Wharf waterfront and watched the first flashes of morning strike the building face, warming its cool wash of concrete into something golden. Before the year's end, the Pirelli Building, whose exterior has never been excused from public scrutiny, can finally be seen from within. One might imagine that a visitor may take the elevator up to the ninth floor, catching a sweeping view of New Haven that includes both highway and harbor.







NO COMPROMISE

Conspiracies, guns, and America's modern militia movement

BY **NOEL SIMS**

"WE ARE NOT CRIMINALS. We are not terrorists. We are here to fight for the Constitution."

On February 20, a month after the insurrection at the United States Capitol, Joey Gibson addressed approximately 100 demonstrators who gathered peacefully outside the Vancouver office of Representative Jaime Herrera Beutler, who serves Washington state's third congressional district. Patriot Prayer, a local right-wing militia group led by Gibson, had organized the rally to protest Representative Herrera Beutler's vote to impeach Donald Trump for inciting the insurrection at the Capitol on January 6.

Although peace is atypical for Gibson's events, the rest of the scene was familiar to me as a lifelong resident of Vancouver, Washington: United States and Trump flags both waving in the wind, a sea of red hats embroidered with a certain well-known slogan, lots of guns in holsters, and very few face masks. The Pacific Northwest has a reputation for liberal politics,

and bigger cities like Portland and Seattle have seen violent, even fatal clashes between left- and right-wing protesters. But most of its suburbs and rural areas are, like Vancouver, deeply conservative.

Patriot Prayer gained national attention in August 2020 when member Aaron "Jay" Danielson was shot and killed by left-wing counterdemonstrator Michael Reinoehl at a pro-Trump rally in Portland. At his demonstration in February, Gibson told me that he started Patriot Prayer in 2016 as an anti-establishment group to address free speech issues through local organizing and activism. He claimed that the group is a "moderate Christian organization," but data from MilitiaWatch and the Armed Conflict Location & Event Data (ACLED) project show that Patriot Prayer has worked closely with violent hate groups such as the Proud Boys—and has often incited violence itself.

Militias like Patriot Prayer form by mobilizing groups of armed citizens who use violence to promote their ideology. Across the nation, militias have been a reliable presence at recent protests disputing COVID-19 lockdown measures and at counter-protests against the Black Lives Matter movement. Since the presidential election in November, militia presence at right-wing demonstrations has increased from 11 to 20 percent, according to ACLED.

Banned from major social media platforms like Facebook, Gibson was hard to find. I finally tracked down his email the day before the rally at Representative Herrera Beutler's office, and he agreed to speak to me if I came to the rally. When I arrived, he had forgotten who I was, but he agreed to a few questions before he heard his cue—a bagpipes performance—to head to the microphone and address the crowd.

"This is just the first step," Gibson began. He encouraged the crowd to take action, saying that rallying and complaining would not be enough to get rid of Representative Herrera Beutler and that Patriot Prayer would need to "put in the work to make sure [they] get a true conservative, a true Republican in office." Following her vote to impeach Trump, Gibson and his followers have declared the representative a "RINO:" Republican in Name Only.

Then, Gibson addressed what the crowd was waiting for: The events of January 6.

"Do you think that President Trump actually did anything wrong?"

"No!" responded the crowd.

"Do you think that Jaime actually cares about the siege on the Capitol?"

"No!"

"No, she doesn't care. She took it as an opportunity."

Gibson claims that politicians knew about the threat to the Capitol and that they ordered police to let protesters in. He believes the attack was a spectacle created by establishment Democrats and Republicans alike to manufacture an excuse to go after President Trump during his last days in office. But it was not just about Trump, Gibson said: "It was an attack on every single one of us."

Shortly after these remarks, Gibson acknowledged that many Patriot Prayer members stormed the Washington State Capitol in Olympia on January 6. Security footage shows Gibson himself entering Oregon's Capitol building and facing off with police on December 21, 2020, after a door was opened to far-right protesters by State Representative Mike Nearman, who is now under criminal investigation. Like those behind the attacks on other state capitols leading up to or on January 6, the demonstrators demanded that legislators overturn the election of Joe Biden and ease COVID-19 restrictions. They also called for the arrest of Oregon Governor Kate Brown. There was another violent demonstration at the Capitol in Salem on January 6, but protesters did not make it inside the building. It is not clear if Gibson was present at this event, but another Patriot Prayer member, Chandler Pappas, was arrested for attacking police officers and has since been indicted with eight felonies.

> "We need to have some kind of patriot commerce that's underground and I'm talking doctors, lawyers, pilots, bus drivers, and farmers. We have to get everybody together and we have to be prepared for the worst."

To an outsider, Gibson and his followers may seem like outliers—a few amateur anarchists that were radicalized on Facebook and got into some street brawls. But residents of Washington, Oregon, and other states with active militias, like Georgia and Michigan, know that they are neither outliers, nor amateurs. Militias are organized, motivated, and especially skilled at recruiting and radicalizing family members, neighbors, coworkers, and social media users.

"THIS IS SO MUCH BIGGER than Trump," Gibson told his followers on February 20.

The militia movement in the United States started long before Trump took office, and it will persist under future administrations.

In fact, January 6 wasn't even supposed to be the end of the demonstrations at the Capitol. According to Hampton Stall, who founded MilitiaWatch to monitor militia activity and the online platforms where right-wing groups plan their rallies, many groups were planning to storm the Capitol again in the days prior to the inauguration of Joe Biden, this time aiming to make it inside the Capitol with AR-15s.

In an interview with The Politic, Stall said that right-wing activists were planning in internet chat rooms to "[kick] off the next civil war," but he acknowledged that it is difficult to determine what is actual planning and what comes from "keyboard warriors," who make claims on the internet but do not follow through on their plans. If there was a legitimate, widespread plot for a second attack on the Capitol during the inauguration, it was successfully deterred by the presence of thousands of National Guard troops.

Stall believes that militia activity is in a lull now, but that 2020 was an "electric moment" for militias. Fences around government buildings will not hold them back for long.

Increased law enforcement presence may actually encourage right-wing demonstrators. ACLED and MilitiaWatch report that militia members often form "alliances" with law enforcement members. In 2019, they discovered hundreds of text messages between Gibson and Lieutenant Jeff Niiya of the Portland Police Bureau. In the messages, which span from 2017 to 2019, Niiya shared information about the location of left-wing demonstrations and how Gibson's followers could avoid being arrested. In September 2019, Niiya was cleared of misconduct charges.

Despite this coordination, however, Gibson condemned police in Washington, D.C. and state capitals across the country in his speech on February 20 for "at the very least [standing] down to let people into the Capitol." Gibson and other militia leaders, whose followers are often seen carrying the "thin blue line" flag to show solidarity with police officers, do not hesitate to criticize and even physically attack officers when they stand in their way.

Stall and other experts predict that a minority of militias will disband or shift their focus to peaceful activism, but radical ideals will become more deeply entrenched in the majority—and they will turn to violence more often.

Historically, right-wing militia activity has significantly increased when liberal policies pass or when members feel that such legislation may be passed soon.

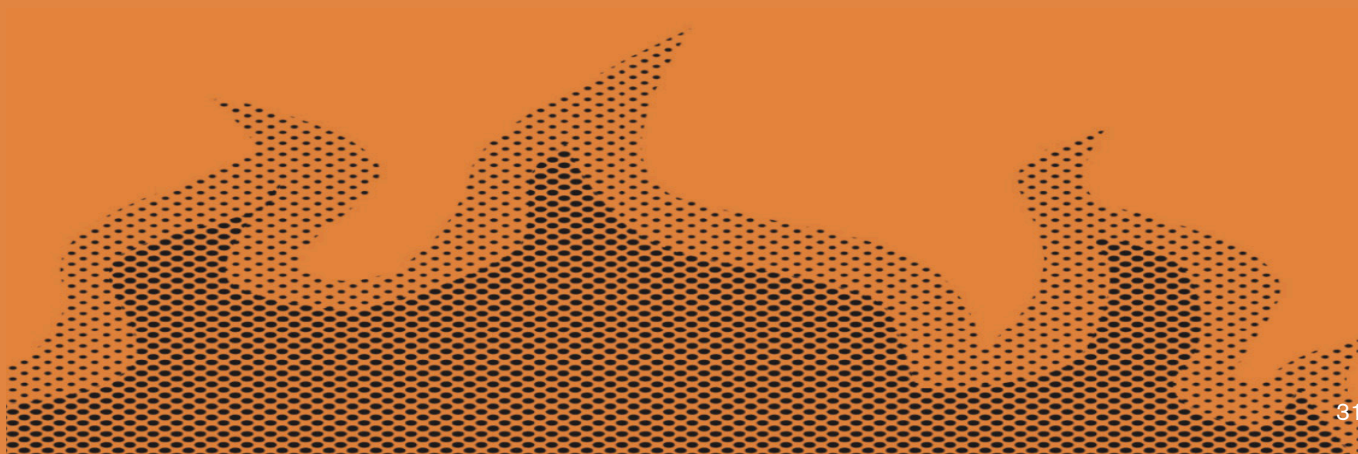
According to the Anti-Defamation League, the militia movement in the United States as we know it today originated in 1993 as a response to gun regulations, including the Brady Bill, passing in Congress. It was at this time that the Three Percenter ideology emerged. Based on a false claim that only three percent of American citizens fought in the Revolutionary War, Three Percenters believe that the government is usurping power and aiming to strip Americans of their freedom.

From 2000 to 2008, the militia movement calmed, but it was revived in full force by the election of Barack Obama. In two years, the number of active militias in the United States increased by 300 percent, and Three Percenter ideology became pervasive among members. Militia members across the country feared that President Obama would take away their freedom, their property, and their guns. Since then, Three Percenters have targeted any politician, Democrat or Republican, whom they believe to be a member of the "establishment."

Gibson's speech outside Representative Hererra Beutler's office suggested that Patriot Prayer would be focusing its efforts on getting more "true conservatives" into the Portland and Vancouver governments through local organizing. However, "local organizing" has often taken the form of violent demonstrations.

Gibson's most notorious incident is the 60-person brawl he incited outside of Cider Riot, a Portland cider bar, on May 1, 2019. He claimed that the fight started after he was targeted while passing the bar, but an investigation revealed that Gibson and his followers planned the attack in advance with the intention of harming antifa members.

Patriot Prayer members have also been known to throw stun grenades and drive at high speed through crowds of demonstrators at left-wing protests. In 2017, Jeremy Christian killed two men on the Portland MAX Light Rail after yelling racist slurs at two young women. Gibson claimed that Christian had no affiliation with the group, but he had been seen several times at Patriot Prayer events.



“It doesn’t necessarily matter what is in the Constitution. Some people see [gun ownership] as essential to their identity, so when that starts to come under stress, not only are they questioning the legal ramifications, but it becomes a personal attack.”

A SECOND SPEAKER at the Patriot Prayer rally in February—who only gave his first name, Troy—followed Gibson’s remarks with a speech about the importance of community among “patriots.”

“We need to have underground lanes so that we can still be able to have commerce, eat, and travel, because they are limiting everything,” he charged. “We need to have some kind of patriot commerce that’s underground and I’m talking doctors, lawyers, pilots, bus drivers, and farmers. We have to get everybody together and we have to be prepared for the worst.”

But what is the “worst?” What do militias see as the ultimate threat to their existence? It is unclear what right-wing groups are preparing for that could set them on an even more extreme path.

With social media platforms banning militia leaders and removing posts that threaten violence, it’s hard to track what might be coming next, but a look into their past might provide clues.

Civilian militias played a vital role in defeating the British during the Revolutionary War and many militia members today take inspiration from them, believing that they, too, are fighting against a tyrannical government.

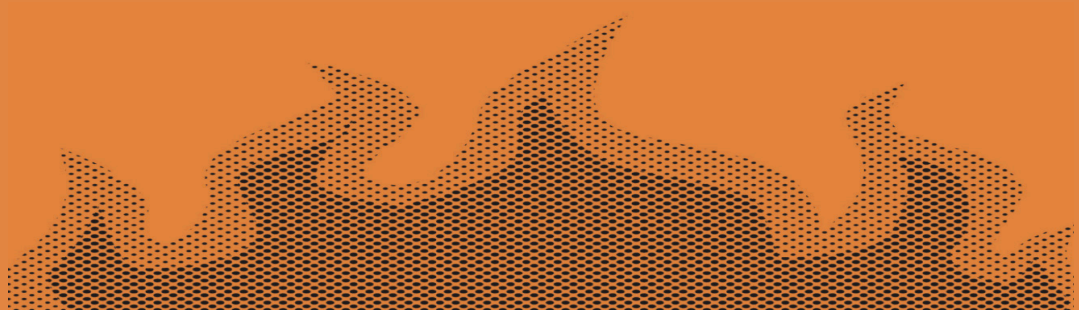
But Kelly Sampson, Senior Counsel for the Brady Center to Prevent Gun Violence, said that the Second Amendment provides no constitutional basis for today’s militias in an interview with The Politic. The Second Amendment was meant to allow Americans the right to form a force similar to the National Guard in order to fight on behalf of the government as they did during the Revolutionary War, not fight against it. Sampson defines current militias as nothing more than “private groups of people organizing themselves around violence.” Regardless, members feel that the right to bear arms and form militias is integral to American society.

While the Second Amendment was the inspiration for modern militias, their dedication to gun ownership has evolved into something more.

“It doesn’t necessarily matter what is in the Constitution. Some people see [gun ownership] as essential to their identity, so when that starts to come under stress, not only are they questioning the legal ramifications, but it becomes a personal attack,” Stall said.

Stall believes that militias, and right-wing activists in general, view gun control as an existential threat—and one that is very much alive today. President Biden often cites the passage of an assault weapons ban in 1994 as a highlight of his Senate career. Now militias fear he will advocate for even more restrictive laws with the help of a Democratic congressional majority.

Prominent gun lobbying groups—especially more radical, “no compromise” organizations like the Gun Owners of America



(GOA)—share this fear. The GOA, whose leadership is made up of many former National Rifle Association (NRA) members, believes that all Americans have a right to gun ownership, no matter what. They strongly oppose any type of gun control, including red flag laws, which would allow guns to be taken away from citizens with mental illness or other conditions that may make it dangerous for them to have a weapon. Even the NRA and Trump have supported red flag laws in the past, particularly after the Parkland shooting in 2017, though they quickly withdrew their support after pressure from the GOA and their supporters.

According to Sampson, gun rights lobbying groups like the GOA and NRA play a significant role in encouraging militia activity. Although they do not openly endorse militias, she says that "[their] rhetoric about the idea that the only way to have a functioning and free society is for people to be able to arm themselves, and that the use of violence or the threat of violence is what rules a state—rather than the rule of law—is dangerous."

Lobbying groups and gun shops often capitalize off of the election of Democrats—as they did following Obama's election in 2008—and mass shootings in order to instill fear about the threat of gun control legislation, encouraging people to purchase guns and ammunition before they become illegal.

Sampson and Stall both agree that if the Biden administration passes gun control legislation, a spike in gun purchases and militia activity is likely.

Gibson hopes that if federal gun control legislation is passed, local governments will pass ordinances to have sheriffs "arrest any federal agent [who] comes into their county to take guns." In his mind, this would be a "beautiful thing," but if such ordinances are not passed, militia members will defend their right to gun ownership themselves by any means necessary.

Sampson pointed out the alarming connection between gun rights lobbying groups, militias, and white supremacy. The NRA and the Patriot movement of the 1970s and '80s—the anti-establishment precursor to today's militia movement—were founded in direct response to legislation passed during the Civil Rights Era. She said that the mission of these groups, fighting against government tyranny, "may seem like a neutral and generally applicable [idea]," but it is really coding for something more specific. The anti-government ideals that inform militia activity today are explicitly rooted in resistance to racial integration.

White supremacy is not out of the ordinary in the Vancouver-Portland area. Confederate flags fly in front yards, and a memorial for Jefferson Davis, president of the Confederacy, stands just off of Interstate 5 on private property. Some local churches have ties to white Christian nationalist ideology and their congregations strongly overlap with militia membership. Though Gibson has publicly disavowed white supremacy and racism, Patriot Prayer's consistent targeting of Black Lives Matter demonstrations suggests otherwise.

Conspiracy theories that affirm and further radicalize anti-establishment beliefs also became more prevalent during Trump's presidency. Most infamously, this included the rise of QAnon, which, in combination with incendiary messages and disinformation from Trump, inspired the insurrection on January 6.

By spreading false claims about high-ranking government officials—accusing them of practicing satanic rituals and stealing elections—QAnon has fueled the militia members' anger toward the government and motivated them to take violent action in order to defend themselves from tyranny.

In 2016, QAnon might have been a fringe conspiracy, but it has evolved into a pervasive, commonly accepted prophecy no longer limited to Reddit fanatics who devote hours to scouring the internet for clues about the plans of the deep state. QAnon believers are young, old, wealthy, poor, urban, rural, educated, or uneducated. Most

The anti-government ideals that inform militia activity today are explicitly rooted in resistance to racial integration.

attendees at Gibson's rally were white, middle aged, relatively affluent churchgoers with a high school diploma, at least. Some were students from my high school, where "Trump 2020" was spray painted over a sign on school property that showed solidarity with the Black Lives Matter movement. Our mascot was a derogatory image of a Native American until September 2020.

Although many internet networks have begun cracking down on disinformation from homegrown conspiracy theorists and world leaders alike, militias and other right-wing groups seem to be able to find a new channel for sharing information as soon as the previous ones close.

The specifics of the next militia strike or what will set it off are unknown, but the history of right-wing militia groups in the United States makes it nearly certain that the strike will come soon enough.

Yet the digital age has made it challenging for researchers and civil rights groups to access the data they need to predict and prevent the next attack. Since Gibson and other key figures in the militia movement have been banned from social media sites, it has become increasingly difficult to track what militias' next steps are. An additional challenge is that many groups, Patriot Prayer included, do not openly condone the use of violence, and they market their own rallies as peaceful, even as they reliably show up armed to other protests and perpetrate violence.

According to Stall, for the last three decades, "violent militia groups [have been] allowed to really fester. There hasn't been legal interest in stopping their mobilization and there is no interest in looking at why these groups exist or why people join them." As a result of this previous lack of interest, government agencies that now view right-wing militias as a threat are scrambling to catch up to the spread of disinformation and planning among groups.

For experts like Stall and Sampson, the severity of the attack on the U.S. Capitol was jarring, though not completely shocking. But most Americans, Capitol security forces included, were unprepared to see such violence.

In response to the attack on January 6, the Biden administration has prioritized deterring future attacks from right-wing militias. But being under the spotlight may only embolden violent extremists like Gibson, who view government intervention to stop hate and violence as tyrannical. They will feel a heightened sense of duty to protect what they see as the design of the Founding Fathers and their fundamental rights.

"Living a life of fear is not a plan from God," said Gibson. "That is what the people at the top want us to think. They want us to be afraid to go out like this, to voice our opinions, but we will not be silent."

PLAYGROUND POLITICS

A conversation with UN Youth Advisor Sophia Kianni

BY **IVANA RAMIREZ**

Sophia Kianni is a 19-year-old Iranian-American climate activist. She serves as the youngest member on the inaugural United Nations Youth Advisory Group on Climate Change to Secretary-General Antonio Guterres. Kianni has been featured in *Forbes*, *CNN*, *Business Insider*, *TIME Magazine*, *The Guardian*, *NBC*, and the front page of *The Washington Post*. She was chosen for Energy News Network's 40 under 40 list and is VICE Media's youngest Human of the Year.

A LOT OF PEOPLE [IN THE U.S.] HAVE BEEN DISILLUSIONED BY THE STEPS BIDEN HAS TAKEN TO COMBAT CLIMATE CHANGE—LIKE APPROVING A BUNCH OF OIL DRILLING. WHAT STEPS DO YOU THINK ARE NECESSARY? AND IS IT POSSIBLE TO RECONCILE A DIVIDED GOVERNMENT AND COUNTRY WITH MORE CONCRETE CLIMATE CHANGE POLICY?

I think that Biden has definitely [taken] steps to make his climate policy more progressive. When he first started running, the Sunrise Movement gave him an 'F,' and I think that [he has] definitely improved since then. But we still haven't seen him support the Green New Deal. I think he and a lot of people around him refer to it as a "Green New Dream" and haven't really taken it seriously, which isn't good. We want him to ban fracking—that doesn't seem like it's going to happen. So there are a lot of things I think he can do better on. But, again, he recently assumed office, [so] I'm not just gonna sit here and bash him given that he's only been in office for a little. I don't think it's fair to prejudge based on what's happened so far—just because there definitely is still time and room for improvement.

But I think the onus really is on youth climate [and] progressive activists—all of us [need] to put collective pressure on him and to make these tangible demands. And it's part of the reason why I really do want there to be some sort of mechanism for young people to have formal engagement with the administration—kind of like how the UN has many different formal engagements.

For young people, I think it would be really great to see the Biden administration parallel that and show that they're not just speaking euphemisms. And they're not just saying, "oh, yeah, you climate activists, you guys are so awesome." Like you're doing great work, but then they're not actually talking to us and taking us seriously.

THE MOVEMENT TO INCLUDE YOUTH IN THE CONVERSATION AROUND CLIMATE CHANGE IS REALLY GAINING MOMENTUM, BUT A LOT OF PEOPLE ARE CONCERNED THAT STEPS TO DO SO ARE PERFORMATIVE AND THAT, ULTIMATELY, LAWMAKERS ARE GOING TO MAKE THE FINAL DECISION. DO YOU FEEL THAT THIS ADVISORY GROUP IS PERFORMATIVE IN ITS CREATION AND EXECUTION?

I don't feel like it's performative because I feel like the creation of this advisory group [gave us] a direct line of communication with the highest ranking authority in the United Nations, the Secretary-General. We're giving official meeting notes to him. While he's giving speeches to other world leaders, he has this in his mind. We also published a report of six key actions that young people want from world leaders, which the UN put out as a press release that was pretty widely circulated throughout the media. Different mechanisms like that give us a meaningful way to participate. It's only been, I think, about eight months since I started, and we're off to a slow start, too. So I can't say it's perfect. [But] I haven't had problems with it.

THE SECRETARY-GENERAL, ANTONIO GUTERRES, IS 71 YEARS OLD, WHICH IS A LONG WAYS OFF FROM THE

18 TO 28 AGE RANGE OF YOUR OWN GROUP. CAN ANY DISCONNECT BE ATTRIBUTED TO THAT AGE GAP, [ESPECIALLY] WHEN IT COMES TO THE ADVICE THAT YOU AND YOUR PEERS ARE GIVING?

I think, on the whole, [when] young people [are] compared to the older generation, we kind of have different priorities. In our meetings, I always stress social justice. I always say, "I really hope that in these public speeches you can talk about how climate change is disproportionately affecting people of color, and how our policies really need to be targeted to make sure that when we have a just transition, it's helping these frontline workers who are going to be displaced from the fossil fuel industry—who really need retraining so that they can reenter the clean energy sector."

In that respect, I think social justice is more at the forefront of young people's minds. On the whole, I wouldn't say there's any disconnect. But I will say there is a difference in how priorities are presented.

THE UN INTERGOVERNMENTAL PANEL ON CLIMATE CHANGE'S REPORT IN 2018 SAID WE ONLY HAD 12 YEARS UNTIL THE EFFECTS OF CLIMATE CHANGE WERE IRREVERSIBLE. THAT REPORT WAS ONLY TRANSLATED INTO THE SIX MAJOR UN OFFICIAL LANGUAGES, NOT INCLUDING FARSI, WHICH IS IRAN'S PRIMARY LANGUAGE. HAVE YOU RELAYED ANY OF THAT CONCERN TO THE SECRETARY-GENERAL?

Absolutely. One of my strongest recommendations to the UN Secretary-General was that he should translate his climate strategy into more languages, especially because the UN has the resources to do that. Those six UN languages, they account for less than 50 percent of the world's speaking population. Half of the world can't understand the documents being issued by one of the highest political authorities in the world. With the UN Environmental Programme, we translated a Youth for Nature manifesto into dozens of languages. Right now, we're going to collaborate with UNICEF to translate their new report that's coming out in a few months into a lot of languages.

I KNOW THAT YOU'RE PARTICULARLY INTERESTED IN THE INTERSECTION OF THE FASHION INDUSTRY AND HOW THAT AFFECTS CLIMATE CHANGE—PART OF YOUR PERSONAL BRAND IS ACCESSIBILITY AND INCLUSIVITY. BUT A LOT OF CLIMATE-CONSCIOUS BRANDS ARE NOTORIOUSLY UNAFFORDABLE AND VERY INACCESSIBLE. HOW DO YOU RECONCILE THAT NEED FOR INCLUSION IN CLIMATE CHANGE ADVOCACY WITH THE FACT THAT A LOT OF CLIMATE CHANGE POLICY IS, AT ITS CORE, NOT INCLUSIVE?

I would 100 percent agree. I feel like too often the

"We're in this situation beca rich, wealthy people have b treating the p like their pers playground— unnecessarily polluting and letting their companies pollute our planet."

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conversation starts swaying towards consumers—that everyone needs to be shopping sustainably. We're in this situation because rich, wealthy people have been treating the planet like their personal playground—unnecessarily polluting and letting their companies pollute our planet. That's why I think we need strong governmental regulation. We need to be passing policies like the Green New Deal.

Of course, I think a lot about using your privilege—if someone's in a privileged position where they can afford to shop more sustainably, or to eat a more green diet, where they're limiting their consumption of meat, I think that's an amazing thing to do. I do think these little things will add up to a certain extent.

GUTERRES JUST SPOKE A FEW DAYS AGO AT THE UN ENVIRONMENT PROGRAMME, AND HE MENTIONED THAT HOUSEHOLDS ARE RESPONSIBLE FOR TWO-THIRDS OF GLOBAL CO2 EMISSIONS. DO YOU THINK THAT PUTTING PRESSURE ON INDIVIDUALS, SINCE IT DOESN'T COME WITH THE STRIFE OF OVERCOMING POLICY CONVERSATIONS OR GRIDLOCK, MAY DO MORE TO COMBAT CLIMATE CHANGE LONG-TERM?

It just doesn't make sense to put the onus of a problem that was created by corporations on the people. It just seems a bit hypocritical in my mind. But I don't think that should absolve you from taking personal responsibility and bettering yourself as a consumer. I think that these are great things to stress. But in a way, it shifts the responsibility away from corporations and gives them a scapegoat, which should not be the case. I think that you can have these two conversations at the same time; they don't have to be mutually exclusive. But I think that one conversation is a lot more important than the other.

OBVIOUSLY YOU HAVE A LOT OF IDEAS ABOUT THE MANY WAYS THAT WE CAN WORK TO REDUCE GLOBAL CO2 EMISSIONS AND GLOBAL WARMING. THE MILLION DOLLAR QUESTION IS, WHERE DO WE GO FROM HERE? IS CLIMATE CHANGE IRREVERSIBLE IN OUR LIFETIMES? OR DO WE JUST HAVE TO WORK TO MITIGATE THE CALAMITOUS EFFECTS AS THEY COME?

I think that climate change is reversible. COVID-19 has shown that sense of urgency is there when it's convenient for lawmakers. We need to continue these movements like Fridays for Future, Extinction Rebellion, Climate Cardinals, Zero Hour. I think above all, the biggest thing you can do is vote—tell your friends and family to vote, and then help educate others about how severe climate change is and what they can do to help, which, again, all ties back to governmental policy.

IN IRAN, DOZENS OF ENVIRONMENTALISTS HAVE BEEN JAILED FOR THEIR ADVOCACY. IF YOU WERE TO EVER VISIT AGAIN, WOULD YOU FEAR RETRIBUTION FOR YOUR WORK? HOW HAS YOUR FAMILY IN IRAN REACTED TO YOUR ADVOCACY?

My immediate family who live in the United States are all very, very passionate [about climate change policy], and they support me wholeheartedly. My family overseas—they support me, but I wouldn't say they agree with everything because they feel like it might be dangerous. It's definitely not something I think they could support publicly for fear of retaliation by the Iranian government. For the past few years, I've been working to translate information to inform them on climate change, so they definitely know what climate change is now, believe in it, and think it's an issue that needs to be addressed.

I haven't been to Iran in many years—not just because of my environmental activism, but because of the political state there [and] how tensions have been between Iran and the U.S. It's definitely a sticky situation; I hope that I will be able to go to Iran one day again. I hope the tensions between Iran and the United States become better. I hope that life becomes better for the Iranian people who really are struggling right now. But that's a lot of wishes.

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